▼ WEST BENGAL

PARACHUTE CANDIDATES

What can make grown men block roads with burning tyres? Candidate lists, of course. It was just past the Ides of March when the BJP put out 111 names in its second list for Bengal. And Triple Nelson struck! Its Salt Lake HQ had to host... er, an unplanned open house for cadre from Beliaghata, Entally, Gosaba and elsewhere. They weren't in a *mishti* mood. Too many names had been parachuted in—not "our people", not "local faces", all "imported items" smuggled in tariff-free. In Malda, tyres were burnt—Bangla politesse for "I beg to differ". The party leadership tried to look composed, as if they had expected chairs to be thrown around.

The Trinamool, of course, has a post-doc in that language. But a schoolmarmish code has reined in the scholarship for now, even if 74 sitting MLAs have been dropped like overripe jackfruit. Only in Canning East did traditional Bengali find expression briefly, with blocked roads. In North 24 Parganas, the Matuas felt done in by both parties. Nandigram was more symmetrical: the TMC has fielded a BJP discard against Suvendu Adhikari, and the saffron camp has replied in kind. An exchange programme! A truce so brilliant that it could be held up as a model across India. ■



Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ ASSAM

FRAUGHT WITH FRENEMY FIRE

Assam is offering quite the masterclass in selective amnesia. **Pradyut Bordoloi**, two-term Nagaon MP, quit the Congress on March 17, joined the BJP in a day, and was promptly fielded from Dispur. Par for the course? Yes, except that in August 2025, the BJP had called him "one of the most corrupt, manipulative powerbrokers". Bordoloi himself, a month earlier, had chaired a Congress session that produced a chargesheet accusing CM Himanta Biswa Sarma of "institutionalised corruption". Opposition conscience-keeper Akhil Gogoi, similarly, had once flung allegations of a Rs 18-crore US property scandal against Sarma's long-time former boss, the ex-Congress CM Tarun Gogoi. But on March 20, he endorsed the late Gogoi's son, Gaurav Gogoi, as a future CM—after calling the GOP "arrogant" during tense alliance talks that almost broke down. Well, as long as they don't all forget who their enemy is while campaigning for the April 9 poll! ■

